nothing of the activities of the branch, we can surmise that, apart from assorted maritime activities, it would have facilitated the subscription of some shares. In June 1909 or thereabouts, the Calcutta branch office was either reopened or shifted to the third storey of No. 14, Clive Street on a monthly rent of Rs 35. S. Parthasarathy Aiyangar—of the Mandayam family which invested heavily in the company in its last years—was the agent. With only a peon to assist him—though we do not know if this was a downsizing—it is likely that the Calcutta office was a modest affair.[34] By the next year we have a brief note of one Amakula Chandra Bose, described as the Calcutta agent of SSNCo trying to ship indentured labourers to Rangoon from Madras and Waltair (Visakhapatnam).[35] Possibly, such agents were not in regular employ but were paid a commission for specific transactions.

Swadeshi Bottoms

Selling shares, recruiting employees and opening branches was one thing. Acquiring steamers was the key. The reliance on chartered vessels was causing much headache. SSNCo had to acquire its own steamers in view of the troubles with Shah Line Company. Without steamers to show, few were willing to take shares. 'If you go to anybody for money, … they ask: "where are the steamers and where is the guarantee that you would have them?"'[36] Therefore, even as the company was being promoted and the process of registration was set in motion, efforts were afoot to purchase steamers. The fillip that such acquisition would give to the Swadeshi movement—not to speak of the promoters, present shareholders and future investors—would be immeasurable.

The press reported frequently on the continuing efforts to acquire the steamers. A month before SSNCo was registered, *India* reported the intended purchase of the *Jaffna* for Rs 27,000.[37] There is no other information on this, but it was likely that, for such a price, the vessel could not have been very large. Two new ships were expected to be purchased either by the end of October or by early November.[38] But as can be